

**ARM UNVEILS CORTEX-A7 PROCESSOR**

The chip that will power most future smartphones was unveiled recently. The Cortex-A7 is built using a 28nm fabrication process, is 1/5<sup>th</sup> the size and more efficient than the current Cortex-A8.

<http://engt.co/qRnZLn>

**WHAT IS OINK?**

Oink is a mobile app that lets you rank things in different places. So instead of ranking a restaurant or point of interest, you can rank specific things at those places.

<http://trcn.ch/r4cWwG>

**THE BEST IM APPS**

These days smartphones are seldom used for just calling people as conversations are forsaken in this new era of apps. Here's a list of the best IM apps for iOS and Android, both free and paid. This is a boon ever since TRAI came out with the 100 messages-a-day rule.

<http://gizmo.do/oUKyGy>

**A SEVEN INCH IPAD?**

If you happen to be a fan of small form factor tablets – particularly the ones which have the magical seven-inch size screens and you wish the iPad was that size – well forget it. It's quite possible that this will never happen. Why you ask? Read on to find out:

<http://gizmo.do/ri4CwR>

# Android Ice Cream Sandwich demystified

- By Ray Walters

We give you the snoop on all the new features in Android 4.0

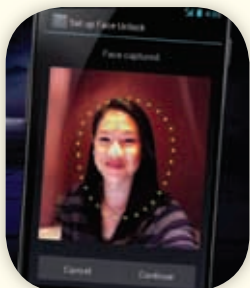


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Like the rest of the Google-savvy geeks out there, everyone in the ExtremeTech bunker was glued to the live YouTube feed announcing Android 4.0, Ice Cream Sandwich (ICS), running on the Samsung Galaxy Nexus. Like most product releases, there were features that had been heavily leaked and some bells and whistles that were pleasant surprises. Overall, ICS is an improvement to the Android platform and it's running on a beautiful device.

The hardware presentation from Samsung did not hold any surprises since the specs for its newest flagship handset have been leaked and reported repeatedly, so there is nothing really there to explore. However, Android 4.0 itself has some very juicy features indeed.

**New lockscreen with "Face Unlock" recognition:** Since most modern handsets have started shipping with a front-facing cam as a standard feature, the Android team decided it was time to throw in some facial recognition and allow you to unlock your phone with your ugly mug. Traditionally, Android had a code number or a drawing interface to unlock a handset upon wake up. Those features are still there, but now



using Face Unlock, a user can simply point the device at their face and let the phone recognize them from a stored photo.

While not a terribly fast way to unlock your device, it adds a bit of elegance to the design. During the announcement, Facelock (that's what we're calling it) failed to recognize the speaker when he tried to demo it. Hopefully production units will not have that issue.

**Honeycomb makes its way to handsets:** There was a lot of buzz in the Android user base about Google's decision to keep the source code to Honeycomb in-house. It turns out there was a good reason for this, as ICS has done the job of bringing the best Honeycomb features to the smartphone form factor.

Check out the list of additions to ICS that are from Google's tablet based Honeycomb:

**Re-sizable widgets:** you can now decide how big or small to make information on your home screens.

**Stacks:** some apps like YouTube, Market and News Republic have a sweet looking widget where information is displayed in graphical stacks of "sheets". With a finger flick, sheets can be moved to the back of the stack in a really nice animated way.

**Widget Placement:** Android 4.0 makes it easier to place widgets on a desktop with a simple long press of the screen. From this long press, a menu pops up giving you all available widgets in a graphical format.

**Soft buttons:** Honeycomb-based tablets have no physical



buttons except power-on and the volume rocker. Interacting with the OS is all done through soft buttons on the screen, which has been brought into ICS now as well. Because of this, the screen of the Galaxy Nexus is 4.65 inches big, with very narrow bezel (4mm). It is honestly beautiful to look at.

## New additions to the Android source tree

With this being a full version upgrade, there were expectations of new functionality in Android, and Google did not disappoint. Here is a breakdown of the brand new features:

**Roboto:** We know you are singing the classic Styx song in your heads right now, which is probably the point that Google was driving after.

The Android team had three main goals with 4.0: making ICS beautiful, innately smart and simple. Roboto falls into the beautiful category. It smooths out the feature text a bit, giving it a more elegant feel. It was described as giving the OS a magazine-like layout.

**Browser updates:** Chrome sync is finally a reality for Android users. Now all your bookmarks will be synced between your devices and desktops. A much needed addition to